Playful Knowings

Exploring Placemaking and Play in Fisher River Cree Nation, Manitoba

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Abstract

By weaving contemporary theory on play and placemaking with Cree practices of gathering and playful engagement, my research presents a re-envisioning of cultural and community revitalization on reserve. This framework is explored as a case study within my First Nations reserve, Fisher River Cree Nation (Ochekwi-Sipi) in Manitoba, Canada. Using Elder Albert Marshall's "two-eyed seeing" method, Indigenous methodologies on relationality, situating, and reciprocity, as well as culturally appropriate participatory design methodologies, my work argues that a playful Indigenous-led practice of designing an intergenerational structure for outdoor gathering on reserve could improve a community's sense of identity and well-being. Material for reflections were sourced from three major data sets: in-person observations in Ochekwi-Sipi, which included major cultural events occurring in summer and winter of 2023-2024; interviews with community members who engage in play, healing, and placemaking practices; and three *Creative Reflections* design workshops, which encouraged participants to playfully redesign objects that reflect their sense of joy in order to re-envision an outdoor place of gathering in the community. Through a culmination of reflections and literature review, six characteristics were defined as necessary for an Indigenous space for placemaking, and ultimately informed my final speculative drawings for a proposed gathering place of on reserve. Research outcomes looked at the strength and weaknesses from applying a western and Indigenous worldview when designing an outdoor place for play and gathering. Research findings also demonstrate an active interest from members to support the development of a place for healing in a growing yet fragmented community. This thesis presents the possibilities of a community-led design practice that recognizes the strengths, assets, and cultural abundance of First Nations, rather than a practice that focuses on deficit, scarcity, or limitation.

Keywords

Participatory Design	Play Theory	Place-Based Design
Indigenous Methodology	Placemaking	Community Engagement

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PART 1: Introduction

Between a bull and a hard place

Reading through Verna Kirkness' history book *Kayas* about Fisher River Cree Nation (p.35), a short mention of a grand story was shared. Its content might aptly explain the heart of this thesis. Below is the story, with added context.

So, it goes like this. In the late 19th century, Canada was intensifying their efforts to control and assimilate Indigenous Peoples through treaties, the Indian Act, and the establishment of reserves. In 1875, a group of Methodist Swampy Crees[1] moved from Norway House Cree Nation reserve to the newly formed Fisher River Cree Nation, 201 km North of Winnipeg, Manitoba. At this time, an Indian Agent of the Crown would have been tasked to control the inflow and outflow of farm goods. Families farmed and fished, selling their goods to the Indian Agent (at prices set well below fair market value) and living in relative self-sufficiency.

On a summer's day, a wide canoe with a wide, center-mass sail was preparing to set off for a week-long journey from Fisher River Cree Nation, all the way across the vastness of Lake Winnipeg to Norway House Cree Nation. Instead of hauling fur pelts, guns or food, the boat was bound to carry a roughly 1,600 lb Treaty bull. The Indian Agent thought it simpler to give one Treaty bull to both communities. However, these communities happen to be about 300 km apart by boat, or 700 km by land.

Why couldn't each nation have their own bull? Only the Indian Agent knows. In the meantime, men would have carefully lowered a bull into a York Boat and prepared their journey for a multi-day voyage. I can't quite imagine anyone feeling entirely at ease—no less the bull, who is very much a land-based mammal.

Knowing Crees, I don't believe the humour of their circumstance was lost on them. I speculate my ancestors grew frustrated, having to haul a bull, destitute to make their livelihood as farmers with less payback than their white counterparts. Perhaps they laughed, finding humour in the absurdity and frivolity of it all, as one does to make light of things. Over time, the phrase "Treaty Bull walk" has been used to describe pretty young boys parading around a Treaty Ground in search of pretty young girls. I suppose those

[1] Swampy Crees are a group of Cree people in Canada who inhabit the northern regions of Saskatchewan, Manitoba and Ontario.

moment of cathartic laughter around campfires, all during those warm summer nights, eventually lit a flame towards my own thesis research.

How have we done it? How do we keep creating space for joy, play, and levity in environments so intentionally designed to be isolating and depressive? Despite undergoing devastating cultural repression, how has the Cree spirit managed to survive on this great land?

Space of inquiry

My thesis research is centered on my First Nations community, Fisher River Cree Nation, or Ochekwi-Sipi. Specifically, I am interested in supporting my on-reserve community members who are actively working towards creating a sense of well-being on their land. Given this, it is important that I situate my role a designer, and how I wish to focus my efforts towards supporting cultural revitalization in a place that is both distant and familiar.

I am status Swampy Cree of Fisher River Cree Nation. I am also of mixed French-Canadian and Scottish descent. My families have resided in Canada for centuries. They've persevered to similar and varying degrees and have experienced loss, success, strife, and joy. My grandfather held deep-rooted resentment against his Cree ancestry. It meant that my father searched long to understand tattered pieces our Cree past. My sister and I first visited our reserve only a few years ago, knowing just two relations. I began building relationships with my distant relatives through this thesis research. Therefore, community and relations mean something quite different to me. But I hope to respect its many contextual definitions in this thesis. If Indigenous-led research with community is indeed "a ceremony that brings people together" (Wilson, 2008, p. 8), I now have the liberty to openly explore a fact of my identity in relation to people and place. This significance has not been lost on me.

In a meta sense, this thesis reflects the contextual implications that stem from the complex experience of understanding myself in relation to the identity of a place. Because this research forces me to reflect on my own identity, I spoke with my sister Andrea McIntosh, who worked directly with Fisher River when designing their memorial site. She and I sometimes struggle with feeling neither part of, nor removed from what is ostensibly our community. This insight made me decide to leave grammatical inconsistencies that jump between possessives, personal, and formal words: e.g. "my/our community" or "their/the community," or "Fisher River" and "Ochekwi-Sipi." Within

context, they represent how I feel in relation to my work. I also write about places that create expressive, joyful, transgressive, powerful, and meaningful moments, so my writing style ebbs and flows between the formal, informational, and poetic. I pay my respect to Indigenous forms of knowledge sharing by incorporating an interpretive nature to this thesis. I trust the audience with their interpretation. My intention is never to negate the warmth and hospitality my community has offered, but to further emphasize the ever-pervasive grey area of Indigenous identity.[2]

I also recognize the unique opportunity for me to write about a personal research topic. Institutions are beginning to recognize the value of what Shawn Wilson describes as the 4th wave Indigenous-led research; Indigenous researchers are beginning to feel less pressured to water-down their narrative to accommodate a greater audience. Efforts of my predecessors paved the way for practitioners like me to decolonize research, follow tradition, and write narratives that "emanate from, honours, and illuminates their worldview" (p. 53).

I find myself conducting community research at a time when the findings of mass unmarked graves at former Indian residential schools woke the collective Canadian psyche. It was a painful reminder of our past, and reignited calls for accountability, reparations, and meaningful action towards reconciliation. The Canadian federal government unveiled an increased $9 billion dollar budget over fiver years to meet the needs of Indigenous Peoples (*Budget 2024: Fairness for Every Generation*, 2024). Urban cities like Toronto, Vancouver, and Winnipeg are leading reconciliation initiatives to include perspectives of Indigenous communities in urban planning, while remote First Nations communities have launched housing, land use plans, and stewardship initiatives to support basic needs and traditional way of being.[3]

Since first contact, the Indigenous Peoples of Canada have experienced a consistent state of identity crisis. A limiting narrative of scarcity, survival, and lack of agency has been too often associated with First Nations communities. In our survival against cultural oppression within the socio-cultural landscape, I wondered about the essential value that joy and play brought to Indigenous Peoples. In this thesis, I venture to offer a

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[2] For more information on Indigenous Identity politics, see Bronwyn Carlson, Pamela Palmater, and Carrie Lowry Schuettpelz.
[3] See Fisher River's Land Use Plan, Saddle Lake Cree Nations Community Plan, and the Canadian Mortgage and Housing Corporation's Maskawacis Cree Nation Rapid Housing projects (Canada Supports Rapid Housing Projects for First Nations in Southeastern Alberta, 2023).

counterpoint to this narrative. I write to shine a light on how the enduring and regenerative values of joy, laughter, and play have sustained our sense of aliveness. If researchers, designers, and community members shifted their focus to recognize these strengths, this perspective could contribute to new and empowering views about community resilience. I believe the conditions for cultural thrivance in Ochekwi-Sipi are found in the centre of this Venn diagram of identity, play, and place. In my thesis, I asked: how do I design a place on reserve that evokes Ochekwi-Sipi's sense of joy, place, and play? What are the appropriate ways to engage with my First Nation community to research this information?

With this in mind, I set off on my own journey, with my Treaty Bull in tow.

Acknowledgements

This research paper is written primarily for the people of Ochekwi-Sipi. This thesis could not have been done without your kindness and generosity of time. I thank every community member who invited me into their lives, into their homes, and who guided me out on the land during my visits. Thank you to those who dared to be hopeful, excited, and vulnerable, who shared their joyful and nostalgic memories of people and places, and who shared their love for our community. Thank you for permitting me to witness you all with such pride.

Also, thank you for teasing me, I probably deserved it.

I'd like to thank my family, in particular Andrea McIntosh and France Jodoin, for sharing their advice, genuine care, and curiosity throughout my practice. Thank you to Fisher River Chief and Council for their support, open mind, and curiosity. Special thanks to those I interviewed for this thesis. Thank you to Fisher River Education Coordinator Kelly Selkirk, my extended family Darrell Thaddeus, Donna Thaddeus, Jenine Thaddeus, and Josephine Thaddeus, pipe carrier Ronnie Sinclair, Grandville Cochrane, Lorne Cochrane, Ben Salmon, Samantha Goldwater-Adler, Emily Carr's Aboriginal Gathering place, and Leah Burns at the writing centre.

This thesis is a reflection of our collective knowledge, but knowledge cannot exist without an enduring care for one another.

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Part 2: Contextualization

> A healthy place for playful exploration is the difference between seeing the world as a playground or a battleground (Gordon, 2014, p. 257).

An Indigenous interpretation of placemaking

Asserting an Indigenous worldview within western terminologies requires a decolonisation of ideas. Place, a meeting between people, culture, and location (Relph, 1976), becomes complex and nuanced when framed within an localized Indigenous context. The longstanding colonial nature of dispossession inherent in urban planning and design makes the act of Indigenous placemaking a form of reconciliation towards socio-spatial[4] justice. Though place is inextricably tied to relationships with the land, an Indigenous placemaking design process is driven by "unmediated participation of Indigenous peoples according to their own knowledge, approaches, and methods" (Nejad et al., 2020, p. 434).[5]

Place and Indigenous well-being are inextricably linked. A compilated review of Indigenous perspectives across Canada described well-being as a holistic and collectivist experience threaded through land and extending beyond the individual (Tsuji et al., 2023, p.25). Acts of well-being uphold the interconnection and integrity between persons, ancestors, future generations, and the natural environment. These acts are undertaken through Indigenous-led stewardship and collaborative exchanges of knowledge, approaches, and methods for care (Nejad et al., 2020, p. 435; Porter et al., 2017; Tsuji et al., 2023, p. 26). Knowledge is maintained through practices of exchange, which is sometimes understood as an expression of culture (Hromek, 2021). Indigenous placemaking is beyond categorical thinking; It is fluid, multidimensional, and interdependent. It is a place of exchange between people, animals, Nature, and things living and beyond living. As Australian Urban Architect Louise Wright says, it means to: "co-belong to a sort of flat ontology of 'space' and objects, a oneness" (Hromek, p. 36).

Although most literature about Indigenous identity and placemaking are about cities, the principles can also be applied on reserve. Like urban cities, reserves are colonial tracts of land designed to dispossess, control, and isolate the Indigenous Peoples of Canada. Alongside the advent of Residential Schools and the 'sixties scoop', the settler-colonial mission intended to weaken community, culturally assimilate the natives, and strip away

[4] When referring to the words space and spatial, I refer to an abstract relationship between people, object, and elements of natural environment in an area, rather than spatial design theory defined by Henri Lefebvre.

[5] My thesis slightly deviates from Indigenous community planning theory (Porter et al., 2017; R. C. Walker et al., 2013). Their work is used to access a wholistic development of communities, while place-based designing is for specific locations in community.

the Indian from the child (Dylan Robinson & Keavy Martin, 2016). Paralleling the advent of urban Indigenous design, Indigenous communities are shaping on reserve placemaking through reconnection. Public support for Indigenous urbanism in Canada has increased (R. Walker et al., 2017). In Winnipeg, Manitoba, they received support for spatial production and programming (Nejad et al., 2019). When youth from our parent community, Norway House Cree Nation, were asked to reflect on traditional activities, some of their memories were inextricably tied to family, practice, place, and food (Islam et al., 2017, pp. 125–126). Indigenous placemaking on urban and reserve land is a reclamation of physical space, while also being a profound, local restoration of cultural identity, community well-being. It is a reciprocal stewardship that honors deep, ancestral ties between land and people.

Third place theory and Indigenous placemaking

Third place theory is a more specified way of putting into practice place-based design. Originally conceptualized by Oldenburg (1989), third places are informal gathering places in communities that encourages socialization outside of the work and home environment. They hold a set of characteristics: Neutral, leveller (i.e. equitable), conversation as primary activity, low-profile (i.e. unpretentious), accessible (i.e. low-barrier), regular attendants, familiar, and cheerful (Taştan, 2023). Conceived as a response to the isolation experienced in suburban neighbourhoods, places like libraries, parks, museums, cafes, diners, and community gardens are all considered as these important social watering holes.

Characteristics of third places have evolved over time (Taştan, p. 277). They include more than urban, commercial, and capitalistic enterprises. Hybrid third places are designed to allow community members to respond to wider social and cultural needs, such as sharing, making, relaxing, socializing, or being alone amongst others. In the context of a reserve, it can include a community-led place that allows for activities like storytelling, passive relaxation, braiding sweetgrass, teachings, and other forms of socialization to unfold. A hybrid third place could support what Wexler's (2011) argues in his research, where he explains how intergenerational spaces aids in the transmission of cultural knowledge and community engagement.

While acknowledging the lack of literature on Indigenous third places, I believe that Third Place Theory holds value within the context of Indigenous place-based design. It provides a framework that is less prescriptive than conventional community and Indigenous

community planning, all while emphasizing the importance of spaces dedicated to tradition, cultural revitalization, and well-being.

An Indigenous interpretation of play and playfulness

There currently exists a well-defined field of Western play theory. Because my thesis is part of a modern reinterpretation of play and playfulness, I have decided to explain the established theory in this field, then demonstrate the recent strides academics have made towards including a larger worldview. Johan Huizinga's seminal work *Homo Ludens* first described humans as innately playful creatures (1938). Sicart expanded his theory to describe play as beyond games: Play is a portable tool for being and a method with which we express ourselves to reimagine our world (2017, pp. 2, 4). The inherently contextual and subjective experiences of play and playfulness makes them difficult terms to define. That being said, they are not strictly interdependent; playfulness can exist within and outside play. Playful exploration can be low-stakes experience, explored within the liminal space between ordinary life and long-term consequential contexts (Gordon, 2014, p. 254). In other words, play is an activity, while playfulness is an attitude (Sicart, p. 22): "Playfulness means taking over a world to see it through the lens of play, too make it shake and laugh and crack because we play with it" (p. 25). While structured play relates to defined games—like basketball, tennis, or tag—this thesis is interested in playfulness done within unstructured play, which is self-led, interpretive, and paced by the individual engaging in the activity (Sutton-Smith, 2001).

In an Indigenous context, playfulness is framed as political, as an expression of resilience and cultural revitalization. Playfulness starts to become a medium to experience a deep, embodied attunement (Gordon, p. 251) through cultural practices, tradition, land, others, and place, all while challenging the personal, social, and environmental disconnection imposed by colonial structures (Gerlach et al., 2014). This can resemble a person's experiences of play when engaging with relatives, their living and spiritual ancestors, or by interacting with their natural environment. Sternos' (2014, p. 14) explanation of the temporal boundaries of social play can be fit within this worldview, whereby three grouping—the person, the social contract within the action or game, and the cultural site of play—all define the space of engagement. For Gerlach, "Historical, political, and socio-economic inequities" (p. 249) are to blame for the lack of capacity for Indigenous people,

families, and children to play. Playful behaviour can therefore be an enjoyable and/or a painfully disruptive method of revealing the mechanisms that govern the social fabric of our society. It can become a self-loving act of rebellion on the part of marginalized cultural groups who have experienced colonial erasure (Brown, 2019, p. 15). Playfulness can reimagine contexts not necessarily designed for play—such as a colonial workplace, a *kokum*'s kitchen, or even a reserve—and turn it into a space for ambiguity and reflection. Consider the men who sailed across Lake Winnipeg with a Treaty Bull. Was humour used as a coping mechanism to deal with their supposed sense of inequity? Indigenous playfulness may be central to the survival of at least some aspect of Indigenous identity, an aspect that has been tested through collective suffering.

To ground play as a means of resilience, we must understand it as a critical part of fostering healthy community development and well-being—especially within Indigenous contexts, where local identity and expressions have long been stifled. While play is widely recognized for its developmental benefits, there remains a gap in research that addresses the unique dimensions of Indigenous play. Playfulness into adulthood can extend life expectancy and help foster strong networks of social support (Gordon, p. 250). Some people might find it hard to believe that they can be playful after experiencing suffering, but a playful state is not an inherent personality trait; It is the result of an integrated, consistent practice in a space prime for healthy personal development (pp. 251, 256). While literature on the benefits of lifelong play are recognized across various contexts, literature on Indigenous play and Indigenous childhood development have largely been decontextualized by our colonial and hegemonic past (Gerlach, 2014, p. 248). It may explain why a scoping review of adult-oriented outdoor play in Canada found a lack of research about Indigenous and land-based forms of play (De Lannoy et al., 2023). Separately, a scoping review by Van Vleet & Feeney, (2015 p. 636) noted that play in adulthood is understudied, and often examined as single study that focuses on youth, friendships, or through retrospective self-reports.

Thankfully, the emerging field of Indigenous place-based design challenges these conventional understandings of play and playfulness. Research on risky play for Indigenous children in Saskatchewan derived from surveys, interviews, and Indigenous knowings demonstrated how "Indigenous cultural connectedness can function as a determinant of physical activity, health, and wellness" (Riley et al., 2023, p. 427) . *NOW Play*, a six-year cross-country action-research project, aims to use play as a tool to improve pedagogical language learning, health, and well-being for children in remote First Nations communities (Ntelioglou & Peterson, 2017). In Shannon Field's (2023)

master thesis, she utilized Métis methodologies to demonstrate the dynamic relationship between colonization, well-being, and play for urban Indigenous families. Emerging Indigenous research is reshaping the inherently colonial space of placemaking and play theory. This thesis hopes to add to this conversation.

A summary of key literature terms

This table demonstrates how literature in PART 2 characterises Indigenous placemaking and play theory. I write this to better situate the reader in my case study. this literature also informs my work in PART 5: Characteristics for a playful gathering place on reserve.

Literature	Characteristics
Placemaking	Meeting place between people, culture, location
Third place theory (Oldenburg, 1989)	Neutral, leveller (equitable), conversation as primary activity, low-profile (unpretentious), accessible (low barrier), regular attendants, familiar, cheerful, home away from home
Hybrid third places	Supports a wider set social and cultural needs, e.g. sharing, making, relaxing, socializing, and/or being alone amongst others
Indigenous placemaking on reserve	Space for socio-spatial reconciliation, beyond the individual, interconnection between people, land, place, ancestors, culture, multidimensional, interdependent, tied to memory, reconnecting to land creates sense of well-being
Play and playfulness	Contextual, subjective, interpretive, self-led, enjoyable, paced, low-stakes, secure, explorative self-expressive, act of reinterpreting context, adds ambiguity, encourages reflection, an engagement between personal, the social contract, and cultural site of play
Indigenous playfulness	Political, embodied, acts of attunement, enjoyable, interconnected, disruptive, cleansing (personal, and cultural), decolonizing

PART 3: Methodology

This thesis uses an Indigenous research paradigms and culturally appropriate participatory design methodologies by applying traditionally neocolonial western theories within an Indigenous context. Because western design practices have historically marginalised Indigenous groups, applying them requires a sensitivity on the part of practitioners. Thankfully, a field of cross-cultural design research is forging a path forward, allowing for ways to incorporate varying worldviews within research. Emerging from Escobar's (2018) *Designs for the Pluriverse*, radically inclusive, cross-cultural design practices value various worldviews while not allowing one to supersede the other. It reinforces "a mutually constitutive process wherein the relations between things (including those who design) are as important as the things themselves" (Barcham, 2023, p. 3). Elder Albert Marshall's "two-eyed seeing" research method (Bartlett et al., 2012; Riley et al., 2023) is a additional principle that recognizes the values of traditional and western worldviews when researchers attempt to weave strengths of intersecting values and cultures. In my work, Indigenous and non-indigenous methodologies were not compared or contrasted. Instead, I weaved them into my context. As a person of mixed ancestry with a inside and outside perspective of the community, this mixed methodology suited my circumstances.

Indigenous ethnographic approach reframes knowledge as anything but objective, owned, or separate from others. It is defined in relation to what it surrounds, its value held by subjective and interpersonal roles that people, community, place, and the universe has in maintaining its existence (Wilson, 2008, p. 53). In my thesis, I documented people, places, and my thoughts using field notes, photography, video, and audio recordings. Within this framework, Indigenous researchers are but the interpreter of knowledge (Wilson, p. 56). The ethical dilemma of our relationship to knowledge is what we decide to do with it (Kovach, 2021, p. 92). In other words, how I decide to interpret and apply information is more important than the information on its own. Similar to how medicinal knowledge, traditional stories, and local histories die off if they're not seen or shared, my role as a researcher is to consider how to facilitate knowledge mobilization and to recognize the connections between living things and the nodes of information.

With regards to an Indigenous research methodology, I leaned on principles of relational accountability (Wilson, p. 70). This ontological and epistemological approach means being accountable to my relations through relationship-building. As part of a culturally appropriate and participatory process, I spent time simply being present in my

community and building friendly relationships with people. All for its inherent value, not as a means to an end. I led with a willingness to develop a relationship with those I interviewed. I did not know many people in Fisher River Cree Nation before my research began, and some became friends through this process. I was inspired by my sister, who worked closely with the Fisher River band. I sought permission to conduct my research from the Chief and Council and offer my findings to community entities after publication. Connecting with on reserve relations prior, during, and post-research allows for my community to influence my thesis towards a direction that better services their needs. It is my view that knowledge should be used to service the community's interests, our individual sense of self, and our capacity for self-determination.

Given these principles, it was essential for me to ground myself and my design process in an Indigenous methodology. In July and August 2023, I spent a month and a half immersing myself in community without predetermined expectations. I built relationships with my distant relatives, played games during Treaty Days, and conducted interviews to understand what gives people a sense of play. This immersive, participatory, and ethnographic methodology created a "space of mutuality" (Barcham, 2023). I hoped this increased a sense of trust, insight, and engagement with community when I then lead my quantitative community survey and workshops in February and April of 2024.

My research was approved by the Tri-Council Policy Statement (TCPS2) [ECU-REB file #100559]. I acquired formal written consent using Research Ethics Board (REB) consent forms for my interviewees. The TCPS2 guidelines do not necessarily meet the specific, local, and contextual cultural practices of my community. It primarily recognizes individual over collective rights, and it does not center First Nations ethical frameworks. I was eventually permitted to used oral consent for photography and for community members interviews. Following TCPS2 requirements was an inorganic experience. It made the process of knowledge sharing feel detached and definitive. More work needs to be done on the part of the TCPS2 to trust Indigenous-led methodologies in the ethics process.

When designing a playful and culturally appropriate workshop for my community, I leaned on Edwards-Vandenhoek's (2018) expansive interpretation of Yunkaporta's (2009) *Eight ways of Aboriginal Design Pedagogy*. The author used these ways to engage with rural Aboriginal youth through the *Marngo Designing Futures* programme. She integrated exploratory, iterative, and playful methods of oral/visual storytelling with non-Indigenous methods of contemporary design-thinking to help participants envision a better future for themselves and their community. Their work is a wonderfully unique,

circular, and iterative learning practice that respects tradition through a “holistic, situated, and relational way of being, knowing and designing” (p.268).

My Creative Reflections design workshops, which I lead three times in February and April of 2024, heavily engaged with a number of these principles. The Eight Ways are (p.627): Person-led story-sharing (e.g. my workshop participants describing their memories); visualized learning process; working outside the classroom (e.g. crafting in the land-based cabin, not far from where the hypothetical place of gathering would be); using playful methods of teaching (e.g. using variety of creative materials while crafting alongside participants); deconstructing and reconstructing; inviting symbolism and metaphors; and connecting design outcomes to local culture and place (e.g. emphasizing that their feedback supports the design of an outdoor place for gathering).

Engaging with community on reserve requires a willingness on my part to hear a myriad of answers to open-ended questions. It means to deeply place myself spiritually, physically, emotionally, and mentally in community. Take the necessary time to recognize my community’s needs, to include their voices in the design process, and to represent them to the best of my ability. The ultimate intention this is to better understand our complex identity within a practice of placemaking on reserve. With these guiding methodologies in mind, I set forth in my work.

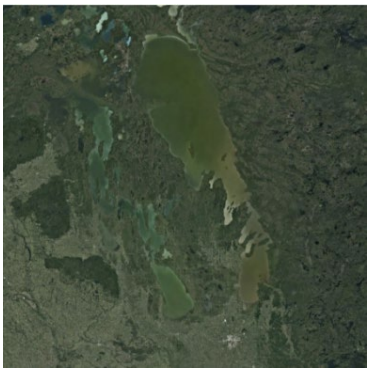
PART 4: Findings

My findings stem from three community-level activities. These activities were conducted on Fisher River Cree Nation reserve from July 15 to August 12, 2023, February 14 to 28, 2024 and April 24 to 26, 2024. My findings are organized into three sections: Land-Based Observations in Ochekwi-Sipi, Community Feedback, and Creative Reflections Design Workshops.

These findings, along with my literature review in PART 2 led me to create my six (6) characteristics necessary to create an Indigenous place for gathering on reserve. This will be described in PART 5.

My findings (PART 4) and my six characteristics (PART 5) informed my final drawings for a speculative gathering place in Ochekwi-Sipi. This will be described in PART 6.

1. Land-Based observations in Ochekwi-Sipi



Fisher River Cree Nation reserve was established in 1875 within Manitoba's southeastern Interlake region. As of 2024, a total of 4,401 members are registered with the band, and approximately 50% of those members live off-reserve (Fisher River Cree Nation, 2024). It is comprised of 5541.90 hectares of land within the Boreal Forest ecosystem, and bordering the shores of Lake Winnipeg. Its natural surroundings include dense woodlands, wetlands, and wide grassy prairie land. The area is shaped by seasonal flooding and temperamental weather conditions, which enriches its wetland biodiversity while also presenting unique challenges to development. Today, the southern parts of Lake Winnipeg mostly consist of Ojibwe reserves.

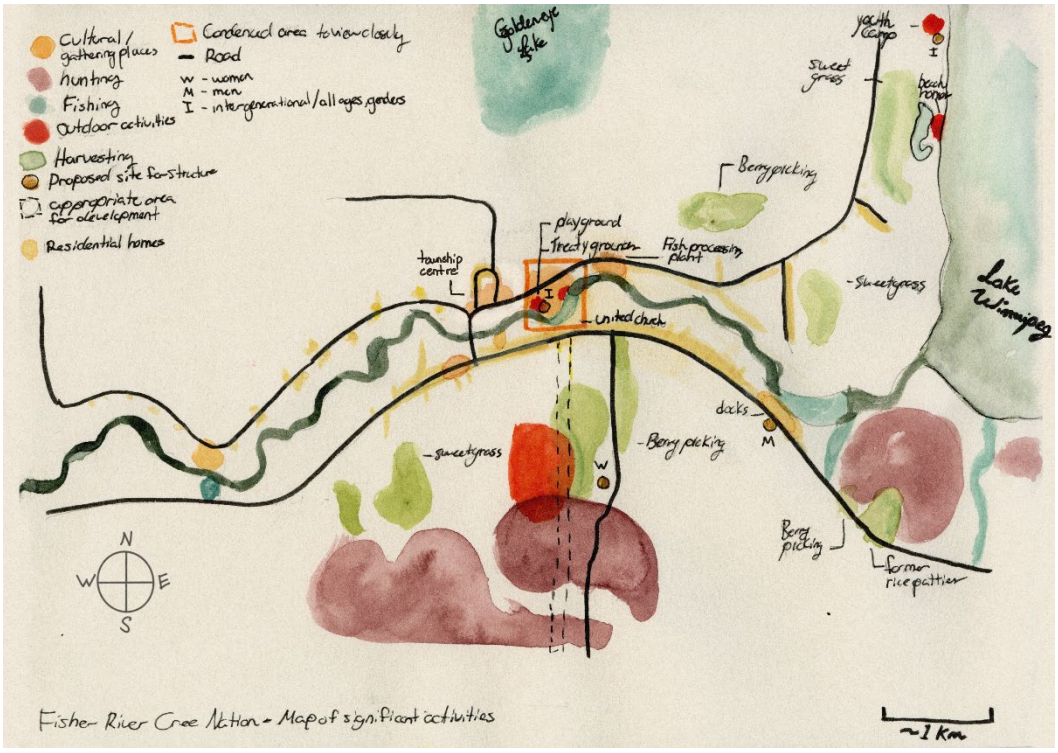


(Google Earth image of Lake Manitoba, left, and Lake Winnipeg, right. Figure 1: A drawn map shows Fisher River Cree Nation in relation to Winnipeg)

This section attempts to observe and reflect on the formal and informal places of gathering that that create a sense of play and joy in the community. I took photographs, videos, and audio recordings of the environment, indoor, and outdoors spaces around the community. I discuss these, as well as three organized social events I attended in the summer 2023 that centered on community engagement, structured, and unstructured play: The annual Treaty Days Celebrations (July 25 to 30), the Ada Wilson "Grey Cloud Woman" Pow Wow (August 1 to 3), the National Cree Gathering (August 3 to 6). These findings come from my observations and experiences: When I was on the land, attending events led by community organizers, and when chaperoned by my relations. They demonstrate the myriads of ways that people interact with their environment and enjoy themselves in community.



1. An aerial map of Fisher River Cree Nation sourced from Google Maps (2024).



2. Figure 2: Watercolour map of Fisher River Cree Nation with areas of cultural significance (2023)

On the previous page, an aerial approximation of Fisher River Cree Nation demonstrates the richness of the Boreal Forest. On the same page, my painted aerial map of Fisher River Cree Nation approximates areas of cultural significance in the community. The intention is to make the invisible, visible. To show the life, movement, and activities that occur underneath the roofs and tree canopies. The information for my map was sourced from my own land-based observations and from the comprehensive Fisher River Cree Nation 2018 Land Use Plan. Initially, my painted map led me to consider places for gathering that were for men, women or all ages. Culturally, there are activities, such as hunting or talking circles, that are led separately by gender. However, over the course of this research, it became clear that my attention should be focused on considering an intergenerational place that can service the wider community, rather than solely a space that serves an age or gender.

1.1 People, Places, and Playfulness in Ochekwi-Sipi

The community's history reveals how slivers of playfulness developed and transformed over time into its present form. Norway House was an established outpost of the Hudson Bay Company during the transatlantic fur trade, so many community members were practicing Methodist Christians. In 1875, a select group of Crees relocated from Norway House Cree Nation to settle on Ojibwe territory.[6] It was established as Fisher River Cree Nation in Treaty 5 territory. Elders recount growing up in conditions where children played alongside farm equipment, near fishing trap lines, after Church, and during sport games (Kirkness, 2015). Over time, play became more defined and confined to the home. I was told children in the early 20th century would play openly outside and run along the grassy main road to their cousin's house. But as children were literally stolen off the roads during "the '60s scoop,' parents began fearing for the lives of their children. At that time, a form of Cree playfulness (what was left of it) was kept subdued and hidden, expressed through language and small gestures: small indoors gatherings, around the table, whilst families shared stories in Cree. Within community and among families, Cree humour has had to adapt and gradually resurface, shaped by cultural and religious differences that pressed and shifted against one another other, like tectonic plates.

[6] Elder Stan McKay informed me that Ojibwe presence in the area is a recent historical occurrence. The area was traditionally Cree prior to Ojibwe presence.

Change is progressive, hard to see from day to day, and never linear. During my visits, children from my extended family played outside in the yard, though I didn't often see children running between the river lots[7] to see relatives. Outside of the township[8] centre, houses are far from other another, further entrenching a sense of distance between people. I was welcomed with open curiosity by community members, asking who I'm related to, why I have a camera, and why I want to write about play in the community. During my conversation with Elder Stan McKay, he noted how often he sees parents out with their kids to events than ever before. The community experienced a past that punished traditional practices. But thanks to the more defined spaces for cultural exchange, people are perhaps beginning to be less wary of it.









(Photos top to bottom: The community centre during bingo night and jigging, the land-based cabin, the open-air hall, and the pow wow arbour in the winter.)

There are more organized activities in community than ever before. Amongst the more prominent locations, people engage with one another during year-round programs and in indoor event spaces. For example, the youth cabin, the land-based cabin, and the newly built Red Turtle Lodge[9] offer opportunities for traditional teachings, excursion on the land, talking circles, crafting, hunting, and storytelling. Elsewhere, the community centre is better suited for large gatherings: It is an open-concept, multipurpose event space with a stage along the back wall and a tucked-away gambling room. They host bingo, parties, and dances. The land-based cabin is managed and used by employees of the Jordan Principle[10]. It has a myriad of craft supplies and a fireplace. People can use the space, if they request access. The Sports Complex resembles a typical hockey arena, hosting an indoor and outdoor hockey rink, a former curling rink, and a youth game area where teens can play pool, bowl, watch TV, or sit on cafeteria benches. However, like the youth computer lab on reserve, it often sits empty.

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[7] Most of the reserve land is divided into narrow vertical plots of land to allow members unfettered access to the river.
[8] Based on the Land Use Development Plan, the township is the highest density area in Ochekwi-Sipi.
[9] Turtle Lodges are built to preserve and revitalize traditional teachings. Fisher River's Red Turtle Lodge has an indoor and outdoor space for people of all ages to participate in organized traditional practices. You can find versions of a turtle lodge in various First Nations.
[10] The Jordan Principle is a child-first care service that ensure that all First Nations children have access to the health products, services, and support they need.

These are common occurrences I'd like to bring attention to. The buildings described here are managed by entities in the community with sometime inconsistent hours, and are otherwise locked from public access when not in use. You are expected to leave once the games are over, and the party is done. This is not to disparage these buildings or the people who manage them; they offer essential opportunities for cultural exchange, socialization, and play. However, it is important to note that they are the main locations for community activities, and they are not intentionally designed for support unstructured forms of leisure, play, and socializing as described in this thesis. The uses of these social spaces are contingent on there being structured programming during business hours. Which does not afford much space for people of all ages or genders to run into each other and socialize. Since the Land Use Plan predicts an increase in population for pre school-aged children by 27%, and school-aged and teens by 32%, and seniors by 50% over the next 20 years (2018, p.10). There is incentive to create, enhance and expand indoor and outdoor spaces for multifaceted forms of gathering.

So far, I've broadly spoken about major spaces for socializing and gathering in Fisher River Cree Nation. In the next few paragraphs, I describe activities that occurred when I was visiting the Treaty Grounds in the summer of 2023, during Treaty Days, the Ada Wilson "Grey Cloud Woman" Pow Wow, and the National Cree Gathering.



(Figure 3: Aerial overview of Fisher River Cree Nation's Treaty Grounds)

The Treaty Grounds are a traditional ground for ceremony. It's situated 1.7 km east of the township area and approximately 750 m wide. Over the years, it has expanded to provide for more services. From left to right, it's home to recreational sports, a children's playground, the pow wow arbour, the open-air dance hall, the land-based cabin, the community garden, the concert stage, and the old Treaty Grounds. It is perhaps the most occupied outdoor gathering place at a given time due to the annual summer festivities that occur at this location.



One such activity is the annual Treaty Days, both a time to commemorate our agreement with colonial-settlers and a week-long celebration of our community through sports, games, and family play. Traditional and western games were played, such as baseball and volleyball tournaments, canoe races, and a big jackpot bingo prize. Less-structured games were equally as popular. The Homemade Raft Races, Candy Scramble, foot races, community Karaoke, and Elders musical chairs were painted with laughter. Because these games encourage a communal act of play for play's sake, they were more about the joy of the experience itself than the outcome of winning. Festivities are an opportunity for relatives and acquaintances to connect in a social environment, and much of these forms of unstructured playful engagements occurred here in there, in between the main events.





On a sunny day, I saw mothers and cousins lounged in the grass as their children played around them, announcers calling the names of contestants and winners, conversing while watching their relatives swimming along the shore while others race sturdy York boats down Fisher River. Locals parked their RVs like sardines and installed seating areas beside one another for relatives to come visit all week. During the pow wow, families bought local concession food and browsed for colourful skirts, earrings, and trinkets. I ran into my friend Judy Murdock and her family the Saturday of the pow wow. We met under the 10 ft long, double-benched, slanted roof seating area, which is nestled between the dance hall, the pow wow arbour, and the pop-up restaurants. We were one of many families, kids, hungry snackers, and blue slurry drinkers who gravitated to this shaded rest area, which felt just far enough away from all the activities to be called a place of respite.





Throughout Treaty Days and the National Cree Gathering, the open-air hall hosted daily community lunches, some mini fundraisers like the pie box social, and dances nights for prize money. In-between events, the hall was used as a place for respite—a form of low-stimulation environment for engagement—away from the bustle of energy that

surrounded it. People of all ages gathered here individually or in small groups to seek shade, run into relatives, catch up, laugh, and chat.

(Photos top to bottom: A community member wins a mystery pie to raise money for Elders; canoe races in Fisher river; men in the tall grass fishing in the river; two members were enjoying themselves during competitive cribbage; members dancing to live music in the open-air hall).











Elsewhere, a show of joyful exuberance took stage in the arbour during pow wow. Pastels of multi-colourful beaded crowns, earrings, pins, and pinned hair ornaments adorned dancers that shook and swayed ribbons skirts, fringes, and jingle cones. The men's weighted pieces made of beadwork and eagle feathers were visually loud and unavoidable. A subtle demonstration of beaded flowers and patterns adorned regalia arm, head, and leg pieces. The smoothed, austere, and reflective braided hair of the pow wow dancers acted in contrast to the bright colours. Some dancers held traditional medicines in pouches, wore buckskins, bones, or wool for to symbolize our role as carriers and connectors between other living things. The sounds of the pow wow drums travelled through the grounds and across the river. This thesis can only briefly describe its qualities,[11] but three-day celebration turned into a show of colour, movement, joy, expression, and pride.

(*Photos top to bottom: Various photos of adults, youth, and children dancing during the pow wow in the daytime and evening.)*

The National Cree Gathering was held towards the end of the pow wow, on the Treaty Grounds, and was open to participants outside of Ochekwi-Sipi.The gathering brought together minds from across Turtle Island to share their knowledge in Cree ways. I saw the attendance 50 to 100 adult participants, suggesting a strong interest to practice and learn traditional ways on the land. Speakers shared their teachings in one of the six teepees (*mîkiwâhps*) that some men in the community came to build. I attended a Cree language teaching inside a *mîkiwâhp* by University of Manitoba adjunct professor Jeff Wastesicoot. There, moments of nervous laugher were heard throughout our diverse age group, when people shared stories or fumbled their words, creating an atmosphere of lightheartedness and humility. During the 3-day gathering, attendants were encouraged to touch local traditional medicines with their hands, which seemed to spark

[11] Readers are invited to attend a local pow wow to fully understand these experiences.

conversation, curiosity, and connection. Two Cree brothers and puppeteers entertained the crowd telling Native jokes, being joyful, and involving the community in their set. Themes of grief and loss were present in our teachings, but the act of sharing these experiences and thoughtfully making light of them created a space where individuals appeared to connect in a meaningful way.

States of playful expression have changed over time in the community. As Fisher River Cree Nation was shaping together from the late 19th century to mid-20th century. Expression of playfulness, joy and community were more muted and contained within homes and families. But over time, people grew curious and began to engage in more cultural activities as a community. Though forms of structured activites take place, forms of unstructured playful engagement occurred in parallel. People also chose to commune with the land and engage with cultural practices in approachable ways, reclaiming space, laughing, and enjoying themselves on the land. When given with the option to connect in community, people engage and create spaces that normalized the cultural process of experiencing joy at their own leisure.

(Photos from top to bottom: Men raise a mîkiwâhp *for the National Cree Gathering; people congregate to eat a community lunch; an Elder is laughing while two comedians play with puppets; rez dogs wait near the sacred flames of the National Cree Gathering; the inside texture of a mîkiwâhp; medicines are being touched and displayed; an Elder is burning sage while the men build the mîkiwâhp.)*















1.2 Nature and Playfulness in Ochekwi-Sipi







When I consider a structure for outdoor social gathering on reserve, I look at how the natural environment influences space. Fisher River's development is primarily condensed in the township and buildings are no taller than two stories, so Nature primarily surrounds the area. The natural environment is a lush colour of green, light brown, and blue in the summer. The forest has historically been cut down for timber and firewood, but recent efforts have been made towards environmental preservation.[12] The dispersed, low tree lines of Poplar, Birch, and White Pine makes the sky seem quite globe-like in shape. In the cold of winter, the river and small rolling hills are covered in snow. It is a painfully bright white landscape with biting winds. During my visits, the large evening skies would undulate with painted streaks of pinks, yellows, and oranges. The colours turned into the night sky at a snail's pace. Nature has a prevailing influence in shaping Ochekwi-Sipi, and could be considered as much a "person" to design for as the people residing in it.

To further emphesize my point, lets consider the Fisher River itself. At the center of the community, the river is a mainstay in Ochekwi-Sipi. It cuts across the reserve separating it into two parts. Families historically camped along the river's edge points during week and month-long fishing trips. In fact, fishing has been a consistent and integral part of the community, in part because the land is prone to flooding, and farming cannot support-full time agriculture. The community has historically been self-sufficient: hunting, fishing, picking berries, and medicinal harvesting such as *weecase* for colds and sore throats were common occurrences (Land Use Plan, p.11).

My cousin and community Councillor Darrell Thaddeus tells of stories of when they used to raft down the river near the Treaty Grounds as kids and bathed on the large river rocks during warm summer days. The Chief and Council of the time removed the rocks and placed them a few meters away long shore. Today, people swim and fish in the river, despite the pollution, and the river rocks remain mostly unused. The river parallels the highway and is the primary lifeline to Lake Winnipeg. Undulating like a ribbon in the wind, its ever-visible presence pulls the community together.

[12] See the Fisher River Cree Nation Conservation Areas Initiative.

(Photos top to bottom: Fisher River on a sunny summer day; a sunset over the river is covered by fire smoke; Lake Winnipeg near Fisher River is frozen over.)



I'd like to bring forward the idea that Nature's presence in Ochekwi-Sipi familiarises people with a sense of temporality and regeneration. There are informal places where people convene to pick berries, medicine, hunt, and skin animals. I heard stories from Ronnie Sinclair and Grandville Cochrane about men gatherings happening out in the bush. I joined an Elder and her daughter one afternoon to harvest sweetgrass on Highway 224 before the start of Treaty Days. There, we created an ad-hoc, informal social space. We got to know each other while sitting in the tall grass, braiding sweetgrass, nursing leg cramps, and sitting on the boot of our cars.

Elsewhere, peppered across the reserve are the decaying remnants of Ochekwi-Sipi's past Sundance lodges[13]. The central pole of a lodge is made of a birch tree and brightly colourful braided cotton ribbons. Anything natural is left to degrade and decompose back into Nature after the ceremony, such as Poplars tree branches, ribbons, and rope. One can come across lodges in Ochekwi-sipi while riding a four-wheeler near the marshes or even while walking in people's backyards. One had ribbons that relaxed and unfolded into naturally new woven patterns, reminding onlookers that though moments never last, their effects are long-lasting, and in this case, contingent on Nature's own process of decisions-making.



(Photos top to bottom: an Elder holding her freshly braided sweetgrass; the ribbons of a recent Sundance lodge are slipping away; a crooked, withering birch is all that remains of this decaying lodge. Photos of the Sundance lodges were taken with permission.)

In a metaphysical sense, animals, plants, and living things act as nodes of connections between people, Nature, and place. Aligning this thinking with an Indigenous worldview, these energetic exchanges are occurring in circular, non-hierarchical sense. While people connect with one another in their home, schools, offices and community centres throughout the year, res dogs, magpies, cat tail seeds, and even sounds of poplar leaves move freely between open spaces, parking lots, waterways, and roads. They engage and react to one another. The natural environment does this not because it must, but because this energetic movement is part of the process that keeps the land's essence



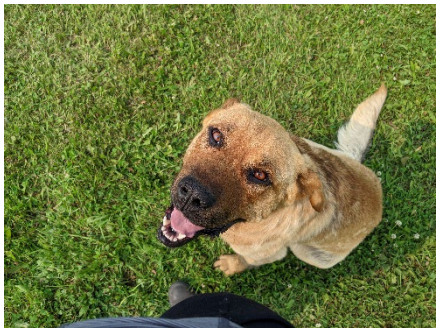
[13] Erected structures part of Sundance Ceremonies, whereby people cleanse themselves by dancing and fasting over four-day period.

alive. Nature breaks barriers, weaving through spaces and helping the reserve feel more connected, creating forward movement that dissolves isolation and borders in Ochekwi-Sipi.

Because the reserve is a mixture of grassland, lowland, and wetlands, more than 1/3 of it is considered flood areas and/or have environmental constraints—including the Treaty Grounds (Land Use Plan, p.18). During my visit, a hailstorm hit Fisher River, and a tornado travelled across in a nearby township. Sometimes in early spring, ice and water partially cover major roads. Winter weather of wind, cold, snow, and rain persist for a majority of the year. Ironically, despite the threats towards the structural integrity of man-made development, residents are not dissuaded to adapt to its changes. People continue to visit the outdoors and live in Fisher River, while Nature continues to offer medicinal plants, berries, and shelter for mammals, birds, and rodents alike. All this underscored the unpredictability of the climate and environmental changes in Fisher River, and the need for a social space that adapts to Nature's ways.

(Photos top to bottom: Ice from a rare summer hailstorm; a rez dog on the Treaty Grounds came to greet me; a wildflower growing off the side of the highway; a forest of White Birch trees casts shade in the dense bush.)











(Figure 4: A representation of energetic exchanges between an individual, groups of people, and Nature on reserve.)

Ochekwi-Sipi—its people, animals, and the natural environment–all interconnects. They engage in various forms of energetic, playful practices in overt and subtle ways. People tend to socialize during organized activities or in confined spaces. But a growing practice of socialization and cultural learning are occurring out on the land and in informal gathering spaces. This exchange comes from an innate want for connection with familiar presences: a want between a person, a group of people, and Nature. This is because the natural environment plays a central role in sharing Ochekwi-Sipi's identity as much as its people do. It dictates its own movement, and when done with intention, people will choose to engage with the ongoing energetic exchange in an enjoyable way. When I consider designing a place for gathering here, I start to imagine a space with as little barrier for energetic exchange as possible. As the drawing shows above, the space should allow for individuals, groups of people, and Nature the choice to freely engage and move in interesting, enjoyable, and exploratory ways.

2. Community feedback

After gathering my land-based findings, it was important to directly hear about the experiences of people who live, breath, and shape Ochekwi-Sipi. During my visits, I reached out to community members by leading an in-person community survey. I also spoke with nine (9) community members of various backgrounds and expertise: Elders, knowledge keepers, community members, *Wendigokans*, and my sister. I sought to learn about what brought people a sense of playfulness, and where they felt most playful in the community.

2.1 Community feedback: Survey

My qualitative community survey was led in the Sports Complex and the Community Centre over two days during the 2024 Winter Carnival. Participants were asked to place sticky notes underneath 32 locations of social gathering in Ochekwi-Sipi. These locations were based on my land-based observations (see figure 2) and on the Land Use Plan. Anonymous youth and adults voted separately. A total of 154 votes were counted. People were encouraged to write details on their notes and vote for more than one location.

(Photos from top to bottom: Survey participants in the Sports Complex, me standing beside the survey, survey participants in the community centre during jigging night.)







Survey: Where do you enjoy spending your time in the community?							
Elementary school	**Elementary (after school programs)**	**Verna J Kirkness Institute of Higher Learning**	**Land-based cabin**	**Sports Complex**	**Treaty Ground**	**Youth Cabin**	**Grocery Store**
				Watching games, sliding/outdoors, bowling night, movie night	Sport game on the grounds	Camping, fishing, cultural practices	
Home gardening	**Community garden**	**Walking along the Road**	**Other**	Lake Winnipeg (fishing)	**Boat Launch**	**Fisher River**	**Backyard**
Free plants, seeds, gardening tips						Skating, playing	Playing
Community centre (gaming)	**Being outside**	**First Nation Healing Centre**	**Snowmobile paths**	**Bush (walking, Snowshoeing)**	**Church**	**Goldeye Lake**	**Places of ceremony**
Gambling and bingo		Community activities: Drum making, mommy and me, women gathering, full moon ceremony					Want outdoor places for ceremony, partially covered medicine garden
Lake Winnipeg (beach)	**The playground**	**Fitness Centre**	**High school (after school)**	**Berry picking areas**	**Bush (hunting, trapping)**	**Sweetgrass fields**	**Sweat lodges**
(camping swimming boating, water safety)			volleyball, playground		Hunting fishing	Sweat sweetgrass lodges field	

Legend
= Adults
= Youth

The survey indicated that outdoor spaces are highly valued for people of all ages. Despite their seasonal access, places near the Treaty Grounds are beloved, while bodies of water are used for swimming in the summer, and snowmobiling and skating in the winter. Transitional spaces, such as walking paths, snowmobile paths, and highway curbs are considered enjoyable places, which indicated an appreciation for the greater natural environment and a desire for enjoyable paths throughout it. Spaces of familiarity, safety, and organized activity, like in and around home and school, were often chosen by the youth. Formal and structured spaces for play, such as school sports, the playground, or swimming in the river were preferred activities as well, indicated that unstructured spaces for gathering could be bear these areas. Adult activities tend to be around community gathering places, such as bingo night at the community centre, learning centres, as well as healing centres, harvesting, and gardening spaces. Though the school offered organized sports for youth and adults, socially interactive activities tended to be the preference for adults, which indicates a desire for spaces that cater towards this.

2.2 Community feedback: Conversations about play, playfulness, and place

Below are moments and excerpts from conversations I led with community members who hold knowledge about play, place, and an intention to create a sense of well-being in our community.

Interviewees	Description
Stan McKay	Elder, former Church Minister
Kaitlyn Murdock	Land-based educator
Sonny Albert	Former Director, Fisher River Cree Nation Recreation
Katina Cochrane	Director, First Nation Healing Centre
Andrea McIntosh	Off-reserve community member, my sister
Ronnie Sinclair	Knowledge keeper, pipe carrier
Judy Murdock	Community member
David Budd	Knowledge keeper
Melanie Settler	Elder, community member

As an active Elder and former Church Minister in Ochekwi-Sipi, Stan McKay has observed the progressive shift from social isolation to outward, personal and cultural expressions in his community. Historically, the Methodist Church forbade traditional practices on the land. Stan during our interview, Stan recalled a cultural-geographical divide between the east and west sides of the river emerging as families clustered nearer each other: Some practiced Cree, others practiced Christianity, and others wanted nothing to do with traditional practices. The youth, remarked Stan, still feel as through they have to decide

between factions—the church, traditional knowledge, or none: "There is still a bit, I would say confusion, and the traditional teachings of respect for each other has not been very strong in the community up until now. But I think that is changing," said Stan. He notes a lack of an intergenerational sense of identity, since Elders do not have the capacity to be together in the same way as before to share the seven teachings (they live further apart), remarked Stan. In some ways, Stan sees how institutions, schools, and health centres separate children youth, adults, and older adults, which makes it difficult for people to carry the responsibility of sharing support and teachings to our young people. "We have to find ways to laugh at how ridiculous some things around us are, the impositions of federal and provincial laws in our lives," said Stan.

He notes how humour breaks apart the tension and despair. "We have to learn to laugh in the midst of this ridiculous situation that has found us in this place." Today, Stan notes that five or so traditional leaders are superseding the church's influence (respectfully). The silos are breaking down within our community as people grow their interest in cultural practices.

Stan observed that part of our Cree way of life has always existed in the intersect between land, place, and humour. Going hunting with his relatives, a family member would slide rocks in father's backpack. Families camping on fishing grounds during month-long stretches would share humourous traditional stories in Cree. It's not the same in any other language: The fable of *Wesakejack* eating scabs off his burnt bum after sitting on hot rocks poorly translates its humour to the English language, laughed Stan. He would witness the older generation playfully tease the youth as a lesson in humility and self-awareness and at other times when seeing a relative clumsily trip and fall (without being serious harmed). He remembers feeling catharsis, conviviality, and laugher with a group of Elder Crees when sharing stories of remembrance up until the early morning.

Now-a-days, he sees an increase of families attending Treaty Days. Celebrations are now two weeks long, and the pow wow has become annual event. This year, he saw children chasing each other with burdock leaves along the river. Women laughed in the kitchen while cooking meals for attendants. He noted how men are taking pride in their work at the reserve own and operated fish processing plant. Some community members organize hard yet rewarding canoe trips – difficult but worthwhile activities that are peppered with good humour. "We are living in the midst of a transitional change," noted Stan. People are committing their time to shaping their multifaceted community, often using fun and joy as incentive and outcome. "I don't know of many communities that do these kinds of things," said Stan, "to commit so much time to community and play, to being together."

As Fisher River's Outdoor Educational High School Teacher, **Kaitlyn Murdoch** reflected on the values of creating multipurpose spaces and learning opportunities for members of the community. Following the steps of the beloved community land-based education teacher Gerry Mason, she brings high school students and adults alike to participate in land-based activities, learning to make shelter, build fires, hunt, and fish traditionally around the community. “It’s something different than learning inside a classroom,” said Kaitlyn. She retains her pupils’ attention by mentally and physically immersing them in a land-based practice, and uses the classroom space as an area for post-reflection: “learning in the classroom… a lot of the kids are bored because they're used to being out on the land and learning,” noted Kaitlyn.

Kaitlyn described how important it is to have Elders, educators, and community members lead accessible and traditional land-based programs. Children, otherwise, would not venture outside on their own. She described how being outside, learning, and being in community changed the children’s personality; from shy and scared to daring and outgoing: “I find when we have fun and we're doing something, the kids actually learn it better than actually just drilling it on them.”

Now passed, she recalls how Gerry’s warm and happy demeanour created a healthy space for people to learn: “He was never serious. If we did something wrong, he’d make a joke about it,” said Kaitlyn. “He would just correct us. That’s how we’d learn […] he knew how to connect with kids.”

As the former Recreation Director for FRCN, **Sonny Albert** believes the community can benefit from a fostered sense of identity around leisure spaces located in denser areas with determined pathways. According to Sonny, proximity to other valued entities and spaces would support the structure’s success because transportation is a considerable barrier when planning recreational programs. People can’t attend many active social activities without a vehicle, and can access even fewer places when paths are snowed in. He explains that the open-air hall, as an example, is respected and maintained because it's recognized as a vital communal space, both currently and historically. It symbolizes togetherness and a shared history. Its significance is reinforced by the major historical

events—like the Treaty agreement—that have taken place there, and its proximity to residential homes ensures an ongoing stewardship and vigilance. The Treaty Grounds are visually and socially integrated into the daily lives of those who live nearby.



As the Director of Fisher River's First Nation Healing Centre (FNHC), Katina Cochrane offers community programs that use aspects of tradition, play, and conventional healing. The FNHC also provides support for women who are victims of domestic violence. To accommodate, the centre has been retrofitted with a children's playroom, a playground, a *mîkiwâhp*, a trampoline, a mini pool, and spaces for relaxation and programs activities. Beyond the centre, they fund the community security program, material for crafting, feasts, medicines, and even couples retreat. This is in effort to break the stigma associated with women shelters and associate themselves with efforts towards positive community-building.

The FNHC has led the *Rekindling the Spirit* program for the past 26 years. Originally developed with the University of Winnipeg, it offers 22 wholistic lessons that empower women to rebuild their lives emotionally, physically, mentally, and spiritually. Participants engage in creative, physical, and embodies activities with one another in a safe space. According to Katina, laugher is big part of the healing program. Lightness is woven into heavy discussions that revolve around generational trauma, assault, and cultural erasure. "It makes sense. When we think of sweating, we have our sweats, when we think of laughter or humour as Indigenous Peoples, it's something that we use to ease conflict and crisis situations," said Katina.

She referenced Margaret Lavallee's *Seven natural healing ways* as a guide that fits within the FNHC's values. Lavallee lists shaking, crying, sweating, laughing, yawning, screaming, and talking as ways for Indigenous Peoples heal. "This was already here," said Katina, "and this is what our people used as a guide in trying to find understanding and how we deal with [steps towards] healing."

To better inform her practice, Katina also performs clown work and accessible theatre for the community at large. The space she makes for laughter and connection permits others to embody a healing practice, be playful, and learn differently. For her, play is an integral part of healing: "Definitely, otherwise it would be too dark and sad," she said.

My sister Andrea McIntosh emphasizes that responsible design goes beyond creating a mirror reflection of the people it serves: It should focus on creating spaces that embody the values and practices of the community and culture they represent. As an architect, she designed plans for a memorial site located on Ochekwi-Sipi's old Treaty Grounds to remember the community's missing and lost members. Her work with Fisher River has informed her practice and supported her personal philosophy about the value of relationships between things: "and that is a wonderful way to see design in general." She noted that rather than seeing an object function as separate (what it is), a designer should think about how an object performs in relation to everything it surrounds (what is it doing). Andrea imagines future of Indigenous design as the way to uphold the relationship between things. "You are in a constant relationship with the land. How do you honour that, how do you protect it, how do you support it, how do you get people involved in it, to embrace it? It's a wonderful reminder that the circle of care that goes into design, it's usually bigger than we could ever know."

Ronnie Sinclair is a pipe carrier and knowledge keeper. He leads ceremonies on the reserve and supported the development of the newly opened Red Turtle Lodge in Fisher River. For Ronnie, tradition, cultural practices, and play are closely linked. Ronnie remembers how he used to walk in the woods alone and with his family as a kid. He spoke with the trees, the rocks, the water, and the weather. It helped him feel a sense of ease and connection to something bigger than himself. "For myself, as a Cree person, I lost my identity, I was brought up in Ojibwe surroundings when I Sundanced [. . .] it was different from my Cree, but it was something that helped me get to where I am today," he said. Now, he leads organized activities in the community to bring entities together and help people follow a more traditional path. He and Dr. Michael Hart of Fisher River organizes sharing circles with the youth to better understand their struggle, which he said is caused by their connection to technology, their phones, and social media. He creates a space for people to feel at ease—whether it be RCMP officers or shy youths—by cracking jokes about himself or things around him. "I really enjoy using laughter," he said. "It's my main thing because it really helps to open up a lot of people." Laughter he said, helps to distract them from being too withdrawn: "they don't seem to feel frustrated or feel left out."

Elsewhere, I heard stories of playful spaces created by people described as Wendigokans, or Wendies for short. Through my interviews, they were described to me as members of a community who experienced a life mixed with trauma, grief, pain, and laughter. They exhibit the distinct ability to hold everything with a sense of levity, and their choice to use humour to heal through suffering.

Described by others and herself and as a Wendie, Judy Murdoch grew up on and off the reserve. According to her, Wendies are emotionally and physically tough. No subject is too serious to be off the table. Even teasing each other when they're in the hospital or on their death beds. According to Judy, the difficult way is the normal way; they take the long way around to learn things.

A Wendie can also choose to help others who are experiencing suffering. During the Sundance Ceremony, they appear on the last day when participants typically feel physically and emotionally exhausted. Some dress head to toe in colourful rags and disfigured masks to hide their identities, brushing people with Poplar tree branches to wipe away their bad spirits and thoughts. Wendigokan Sundance outfits are unkempt, a mismatch of material used as a means to transmit more than oneself and create space for playful healing. Judy's dress was a long brown momo-like shape made of broadcloth, side fridges, a belt, a big nose, and one large ear made of burlap and stuffing. It was sewn any old way, with full of imperfections. Their unserious attires were intended to be disarming for weary onlookers.

Judy has been both a participant and a Wendie during ceremony. She would feel energized hearing the distant jingles of bells, howls, and yells from the Wendies coming out of the bush and towards the Sundance lodge. She remembered once during a Sundance when the clouds began to drizzle with rain: "it came to awaken your spirits again as you were dancing."

Judy felt like she had found her role. She recalled feeling a sense of pride and belonging when she felt part of something bigger than herself. She found a space to heal, heal others, and express connection on a physical and spiritual level. She attributes her joy the ability to fully purse a joyful traditional practice. "Everyday is a ceremony," she says. Looking back at her childhood, play was a form of escapism, synonymous with the abuse

she experienced growing up in a dysfunctional family. But today, Judy is spending time to sooth her inner child, to “stop protecting her and [let her inner child] go out and play.” She does this in part by being in Nature, conversing with plants and developing a caring relationship with rocks and living things. Where she was once wary of letting her children play in the bush, she encourages her granddaughter to play out late on her property, where the beavers nest near the shore, and the northern pike swim upstream.

I also interviewed David Budd, a healer, helper, and to some, and Elder from Ochekwi-Sipi while he was attending the final day of Peguis First Nation’s Sundance ceremony. Elders told David he was Wendie in his early adult life. Ever since, he has been involved in countless ceremonies over the last 20 years: “Wendigokans go in there to take away the sickness, the hurt and the pain,” said David. Committed to his traditional way of life, David feels that a space for play and healing is created when we first honour our identity through spiritual reconnection and expression. For him, the journey towards reconnecting with ourselves will lend to a practice of playful expression. “As you’re starting to find yourself, you’ll start to feel a bit more comfortable about yourself. You start to smile; it slowly comes on subtly. You start to smile a little bit more, and you feel safe,” remarked David.

He recalled when he once participated in creating a space for a playful healing practice. He once attended an ordinary conference in Winnipeg with a group of Wendies to heal a crowd of volunteers. The conference room lights turned off. Rattles shook; drums were roaring. David remembered the energetic sounds of crying, laughter, and singing as Wendies approached people. A space was made. He recalled tying the shoes of one participant he knew, as a playful gesture to connect with him and to remind the participant of life’s levity. For David, dressing as a Wendie evokes his more transcendent sense of self: “The Wendie way of life is basically waking up the human,” he said.



“The number one thing Elders gave me was their love. Oh, they loved me until I could love myself, and what joy that is when you find that in yourself,” said **Melanie Settler**. Melanie is an Elder and Wendie from Ochekwi-Sipi who now lives in Winnipeg. She remembered how she created safe spaces for people to be themselves, due in part to the support she experienced as a youth in the community. With the support of her ancestors, she walks alongside people in their healing journey by offering support and levity, and by being present and authentic. Creating a space for play for her included trust, laughter, stability, consistency, care, and absence of judgment.



As reflected both from my community survey and conversations a place that encourages a sense of playfulness emerges from a practice rooted healing and mutual care. Survey findings from community highlights a strong appreciation for outdoor and familiar spaces, where people of all ages feel secure and joyful. This underscored the value of unstructured and structure environments for engagement. It also aligns with insights gathered from my interviews, which revealed that healing is often interwoven with playful practices that foster resilience and connection. The examples of Wendies engaging in playful but intentional actions during ceremony demonstrate how humour and laughter serve as both a method to create playfulness as an outcome that reinforces it. Though the FNHC’s leads their *Rekindling the Spirit* program indoors, they offer programs that weave humour and connection to strengthen community. Inclusive spaces, where the well-being of the youth, for culture, and for outdoor connection are resurging in a reserve originally designed to isolate and repress forms of Indigenous cultural expression. Community leaders are transforming everyday places into accessible spaces that help people connect with themselves, each other, and with Nature. Where play and playfulness were once a means of survival, it is now becoming a way to foster curiosity, connection, and care.

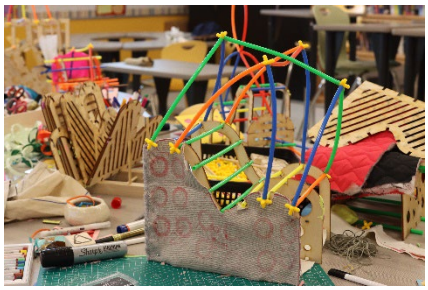
3. Creative Reflections Design Workshops

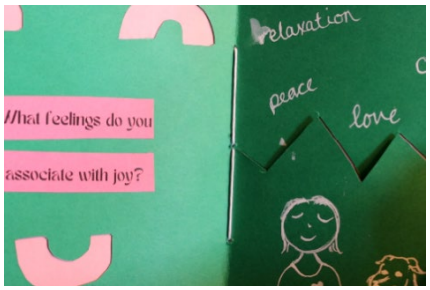






















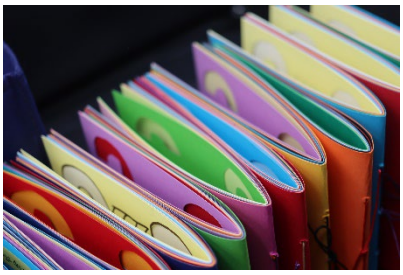






With a better understanding of Ochekwi-Sipi's land and community, I led three (3) Creative Reflections design workshops February 20th, 23rd, and April 24th, 2024. In the previous sections, I spoke with members who are engaged in community-building, placemaking, and playful practices. In this section, I interchange the words joy and playful.[14] Workshop participants were community members at large. Inspired by the *Eight Ways of Aboriginal Design Pedagogy*, they were encouraged to share their personal thoughts about playfulness through creative reflection and abstract form-making, translating their experiences into words, symbols, shapes, and objects. My intention was to further understand peoples' intuitive and latent interests surrounding community and playfulness. Exploring non-verbal expressions could provide a more comprehensive insight into how I can create a sense of place on reserve.







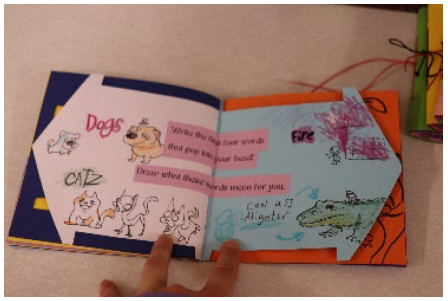
Two workshops were led in Fisher River's Land-based cabin[15]: One during the weekly men's gathering, and another during the Winter Carnival. The last workshop was held at the Fisher River High School for six high school students. There was a total of 15 participants. They were comprised of youths, adults, seniors, and Elders from Ochekwi-Sipi. Members of Fisher River's Jordan Principle helped me secure the land-based cabin and assisted as recruiters and participants. Other participants were recruited through word-of-mouth and by posters I created and shared through the Chief and Council's social media accounts.

The workshop was divided into three parts. 1) Participants redesigned a unique booklet to depict their joyful experiences in Ochekwi-Sipi. 2) Inspired by their booklet, participants built their own playful structure using a variety of hands-on, tactile materials. 3) The workshop ended with a brief presentation of their process and demonstration of their models. Gifts of art supplies were offered to participants as a form of reciprocity, but few were taken.

Inspired by designer Bruno Murani's *Libro Illiggibile* (Illegible Book), the booklet was designed to be playful, approachable, and intuitive, with each step building progressively off the last. First, a step-by-step, emotion-association line-drawing exercise acted as

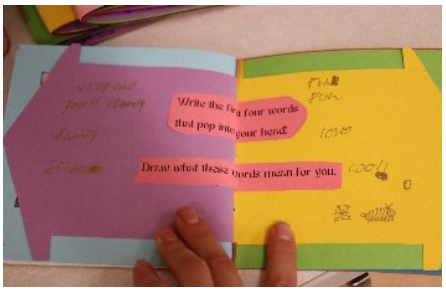
[14] I shared with participants a mind map of words associated with joy rather than playful. My test workshops indicated that when I asked participants to think of playful moments in their lives, it was too abstract of a task, and therefore too demanding.
[15] Readers can revisit Figure 2 on page 22 to situate themselves.

warm up exercise to ease participants away from a possibly daunting creative process. When prompted to draw and cut freely into their book. Participants were later asked to write in their booklet thoughts they associate with joy and community. They used a variety of colourful pencils, chalk, colour markers, acrylic, string, and glue for their answers. To encourage a sense of ownership and levity, participants were invited to continue altering their booklet and take it home after the end of the exercise.









What Words do you associate with joy? Think of a time you had fun in the community. Write and draw these four words.	
Low stimulation: passive relation	Peaceful, joy, appreciated, inspired, carefree, pleasure, relaxation (3), confident, chilling, being mellow, cool, calmness, sleepy, peace, love (2), content (3), comfortable, sleep (3), restfulness, music (3), resting figure, satisfaction, wellness, smile
High stimulation: play and movement	Fun (3), playful, energetic, upbeat (2), chipper, creative, build, musical instruments, art, video games, volleyball, bowling at the Sports Complex, parade
Connection and community	Family (3), gathering, men, uncles, friends (5), food (3), people (2), talking, father and son saying "thank you" and "you're welcome," socializing, shaking hands, Peguis Treaty Days, Fisher River Treaty Days (2)
Outdoors and Nature	Walking, camping, camper van, trailer bench, canoes, water, waves, hot, sun (4), sweats, laying in the sun with a cold drink, walking, Nature, plants, grass, flowers (2), adventure, riding a four-wheeler, animals, dog, rez dogs (2), star gazing, rainbow

This table organizes the prompts, words, and drawing depictions[16] participants described in their booklet. I organized all responses[17] to two questions into categories of engagement. The numbers associated with the words represent the total amount of times they were repeated by separate participants.

Based on these words, it could be seen that many participants depicted representations of joy that were familiar and accessible to them, such as being with family and friends, their home, or playing sports. The joyful activities tended to be high-energy and low-energy interactions between themselves, people, and the environment using

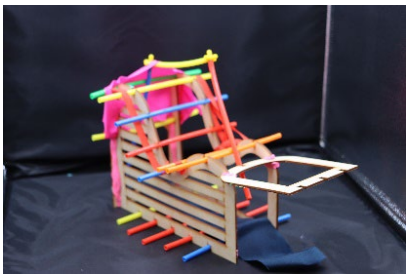
[16] I did not register all the words from the men's group. At the time, it felt inappropriate.
[17] Not all participants returned their booklets, so this data is drawn from only those returned booklets.

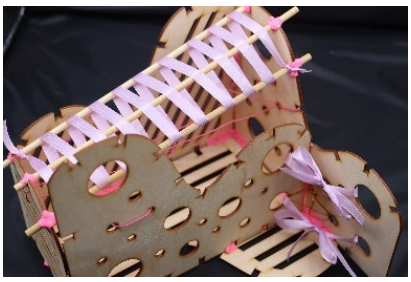
observational, verbal, and tactile methods of engagement relied on little to no technology. Participants shared similar values around leisure, quality time with themselves, others, and connecting with Nature, where proximity to and movement through natural spaces played a key role in how they enjoy themselves. Spaces that accommodate these needs, resemble a park or playground, where socializing near a fence or bench, engaging in active play, or having some respite under a tree offers participants sense of agency in how they want to regulate themselves. A space that imbues these values can provides a choice for participants to interpret and engage with their surroundings in a way meaningful way.

After a short break, participants began the second half of the workshop. They were prompted to design a structure that represented the words and images they depicted in their booklet. They used a variety of colourful, natural hands-on material like plywood cut-outs, nylon, fabric, ribbons, putty, strings, elastics, straws, stamps, and cut-out paper. This material was meant to prompt deeper reflection by encouraging personal, intuitive, and open-ended exploration. I also reiterated that their feedback would help inform a space for community gathering on reserve. As to not overwhelm participants, they followed my step-by-step instructions: use putty to adhere three to five pieces of patterned plywood cut-outs; grab kinetic straws or bamboo sticks to connect your structure; use pieces of string or ribbons to embellish or connect; lastly, option to use fabric or paper material to add dimension. Afterwards, participants took a minute to share their thoughts about their structure.

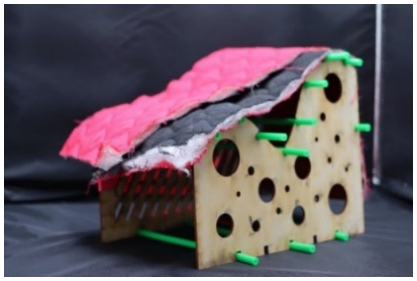
For some, their structure took on a metaphorical shape to mean a place of invitation for story and connection. Similar to non-linear forms of Indigenous storytelling, one participant used circular plywood cut-out as a jumping off point to share a story of how Crees are star people, or straws to discuss the symbolic meaning of colour for Crees. Demonstrating an intention to offer care, some used opened, closed, and swinging doors to represent pathways for self-healing and healing for others.

For others, a structure for gathering held values of safety and familiarity. Many modeled their structure as homes, or spaces to house their family, other people, and themselves. One participant chose ribbons and coloured markers that reminded them of a family member who passed. Others cut ribbons into window curtains, some used quilted fabrics as a makeshift roof, others used ribbons and string to represent a calm contained space for their busy mind. All chose materials that highlight personal memories, and representations show how a gathering place can embody a sense of comfort.







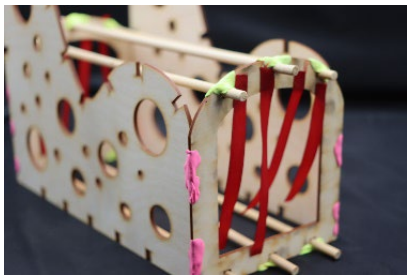


It is important to note that participants also created structures purely for fun, embracing the workshop's focus on playfulness and creative freedom. This approach encouraged uninhibited exploration, aligning with the goal of fostering joy and community-centered design: e.g. a giant play space with a mesh sail and swing, a line of rubber-stamped patterns, and intricate architectural feats explored the limits of the material. The playful structures embodied the very essence of the workshop's goal: to cultivate a joyful, communal approach to design that prioritizes the values and experiences of the participants, rather than strictly focusing on utilitarian outcomes. Even without a strict functional purpose, these playful creations reflected the thesis' emphasis on process, connection, and community relationship-building.





Meeting people in familiar places and presenting myself to my relations helped create an environment where people felt at ease to think about what they enjoy about being out in community. The flexible workshop structure allowed participants to contribute at their own comfort level, whether through complex interpretive pieces, playful drawings, or by choosing not to be photographed or share their thoughts. My design workshops were conceptual and abstract at times, so it was crucial to meet people where they were, giving them agency to decide their degree of participation.



Through the Creative Reflections design workshops, participants demonstrated ways for a place to foster a sense of playfulness and community on reserve. From group interactions and conversations to more quiet and reflective communions with Nature, participants chose to depict a range of individual and group activities that require little no to complex structural support. This demonstrates a want for a space where individuals have the agency to freely explore and express themselves. Participants integrated symbolism and storytelling when describing their structures—such as referencing Cree teachings—which indicates a want for a place to enable cultural or spiritual teachings. Participants also described spaces that emphasized exchanges with community: People of different genders, ages, or with the environment. This was further shown through designs that represented family, communal gatherings, and shared memories. There were depictions of places that were familiar and comfortable to participants, places that were close to home and in common areas of gathering. People made structures that were recognizable and secure by incorporating materials and colours that reminded them of family members or their house. They also valued activities that were easy to access, simple to do, and easy to repeat, such as going out in Nature or listening to music. Overall, their interests point to a preference for immersive, full-bodied experiences. This speaks to the need for a multipurpose space for play that is open-ended and adaptable.



PART 5: Characteristics for a playful gathering place on reserve

My contextualization and findings from my land-based observations, community feedback, and workshops have led me to speculate on six (6) characteristics necessary to create a place for gathering that fosters forms of playful and joyful engagement on reserve. In no particular order, the characteristics are as follows:

Characteristics	Description
Agency	Autonomous self-led exploration and self-expression allows individuals, people and the natural environment to dictate movement and engagement within the place. The design also recognizes equity between each group. A design would afford the option for participants to engage in high-energy activity (social conversation, children playing, teachings) or low-energy activity (resting, being outdoors, in proximity to others). In this context, creativity is inherent in personal expression.
Spiritual and cultural practice	A space for the community culture to take its form: A meeting place for relatives, children, youth, adults and elders to participate in storytelling, conversation with Elders, Pastors/Spiritual Leaders, knowledge keepers, and land-based practitioners. Encourages ritual and pattern formation. Community social buffers (e.g. community fire, coffee, smudging) allows people who aren't familiar with each other to get acquainted.
Interconnection	An intergenerational place that encourages connections between children, youth, adults, elders, as well as spiritual ancestors and the natural environment. A space also encourages us to reflect on our future generations. It affords the option to be in proximity to others to various degrees.
Familiarity and proximity	A design should be in proximity to preexisting reserve landmarks or locations of social gathering (formal or informal) to evoke a sense of familiarity, ease, and security for people engaging in space. To be adopted, the design must exude cultural characteristics of the community and land to better represent their identity. The design should encourage proximity with self, others and the natural environment.
Accessible	Not only in terms of mobility, but a place requires little physical barrier to access (e.g. fences, gates, operational hours) and should afford community-level maintenance. The design should accommodate for climate and environmental conditions. Designing with this in mind allows for consistent, habit-forming practices to unfurl.
Enjoyable	Experiences of joy that are embodied or cerebral but does not require predefined activity. Includes contentment, mindfulness, laughter, teasing, and the sensation of reconnecting with others. Part of a process of shedding internalized colonial oppression as a form of self-healing. Overcoming suffering is also considered part of a process to bring out a sense of joy, though not always necessary. The experience of joy can transcend individual experiences and extend to shared experiences between a person, others, and the natural environment.

In this context, the role of a designer is to act as an "architect of play," and create a system of engagement for people (Sicart, 2017, p. 24). Rather than designing a toy or a game, a playful designer creates the space—or "stage"—that provides opportunities for people to self-direct their expressive, playful states (p. 90). In my research, I believe these characteristics[18] help to create this stage in my reserve.

They are an attempt to meet the intrinsic needs of community members as it relates to placemaking and play on reserve. They recognize the broader cross-cultural influences inherent in my community and encourage the simultaneous fluxes of energy exchange between individuals, others and Nature. I recognize the importance of offering space for traditional practices, as many Elders and community members have told me. However. I believe the sum of these characteristics will ensure a broader, more multipurpose space for gathering. A place that can meet the underlying needs of the community. A place that first fosters a sense of safety and well-being, then leads to a sense of play and enjoyment. While current gathering spaces in Fisher River area are activated during special events, organized activities, indoors, at home, and increasingly out on the land, my six characteristics encourage the development of a place for more informal types of gathering. As you will see in PART 6, the development around the six characteristics does not require complex architectural feats, a formal program, or even four walls and a roof. They require an interpretive space that embodies the values of Ochekwi-Sipi

[18] The word characteristics is defined here as a distinctive attribute that shapes the environment.

PART 6: Speculative drawings of *âniskômohcikewin*

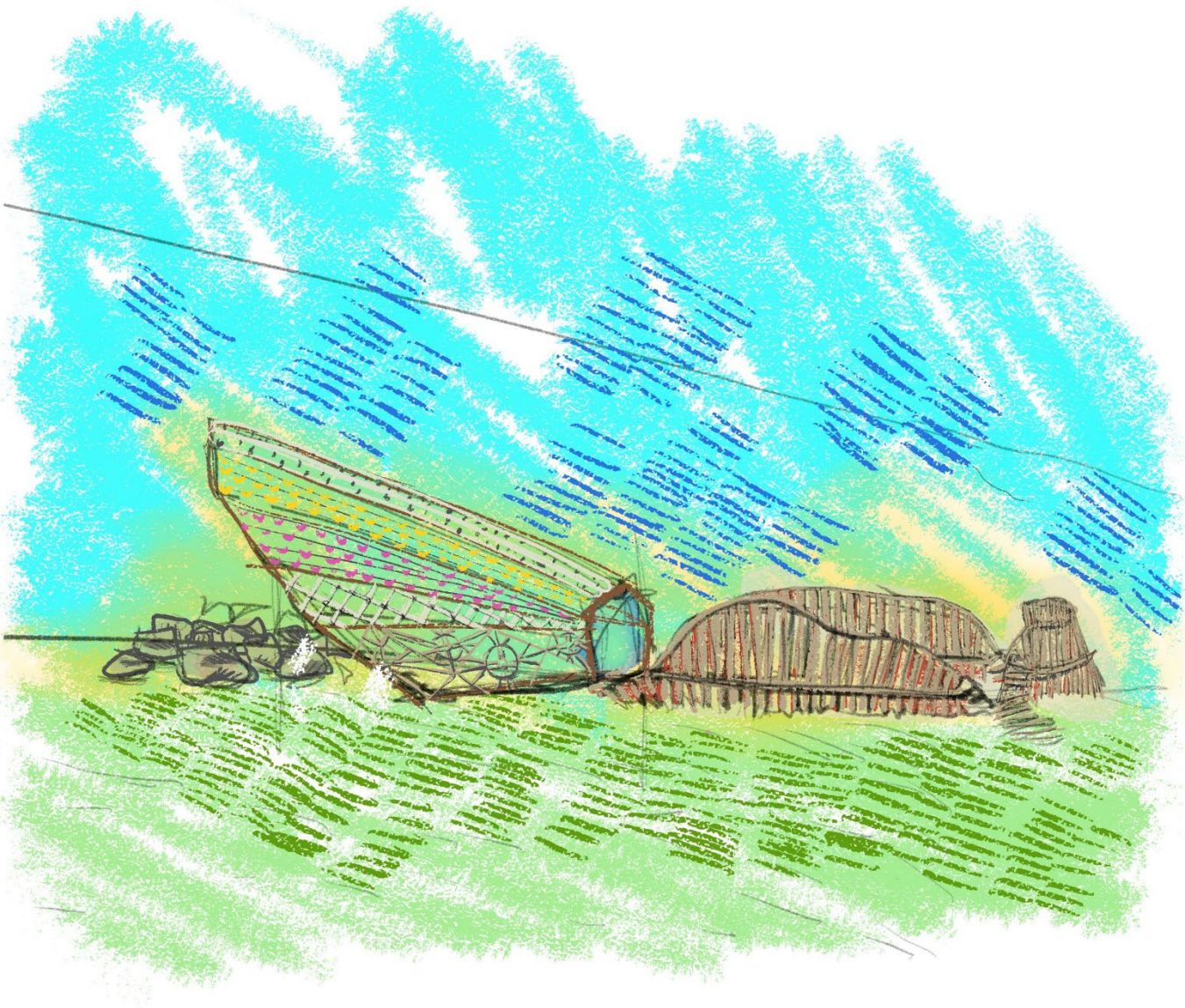


Figure 5: Panoramic drawing of *âniskômohcikewin*

The speculative[19] gathering place is named *âniskômohcikewin*, the Cree word meaning connections. *âniskômohcikewin* is not intended to be an architectural design. Since I have established that certain conditions must be met for people to enter into a playful state, the speculative design is meant to be an inspiring and creative embodiment of the six characteristics. This section explains how *âniskômohcikewin* embodies the six characteristics.

âniskômohcikewin is situated on the Treaty Grounds, slightly east of the land-based cabin. It is divided into three parts: At the top, curved benches made of natural lumber create three separate semi-circles around a central firepit. Their edges descend into lumber slat walkways that travel in opposite directions, indicating points of entry. The centre structure has ten panels that support materials that react differently in response to the year-round environment. Inside, two benches would follow along the sides of the structure and are separated by a slatted walkway. In the third and last section of *âniskômohcikewin*, an array of repurposed river rocks offer an additional place for members to sit separately or together. The sense of scale in my drawings is intended to visualize how the space acts as a communal gathering place and exists in reaction to the natural environment. Given this explanation, I imagine *âniskômohcikewin* as being approximately 30 meters in length, 5 meters in width, and 6 meters in height.

Inspired by the six characteristics, *âniskômohcikewin* is also intended to be a joyful visual representation Ochekwi-Sipi's fishing history: From top to bottom, people and animals would move into the narrow mouth of the central structure like fish, which is inspired by the shape of fishing boats and fishing traps. They then exit through the bottom half, around the rapid rocks and into the metaphorical river. Know that the wide mouth opening of the centre structure faces the river, which is approximately 150 meters away.

[19] While the term "speculative" in design is often used to refer to the exploration of hypothetical futures and alternative scenarios, "speculative" here refers simply to an informed exploration.



Figure 6: Aerial drawing of âniskômohcikewin *east of the land-based cabin, four other buildings in the area, and a semi-dense bush.*



Figure 7: Bench Drawing. The open and slatted back seat of the bench allows for visibility between people and the natural environment, while the slatted pathway creates an inviting atmosphere.

Agency

âniskômohcikewin undefined Nature is intended to encourage a form of self-led exploration, definition, and connection with the space. Its shape accommodates for various degrees of interests, capacity, and levels of engagement. As well, its meandering path of travel and porous, abstract shape is designed to encourage free movement for individuals, people, and Nature. Community members can explore, rest, and engage with the outdoors at a comfortable, self-led pace (e.g. they can engage in low-sensory introspection by resting on one of the many benches or lead sharing circles around the fire, or choose to go between the two). Participants can determine their relationship with the space through self-guided meaning-making.

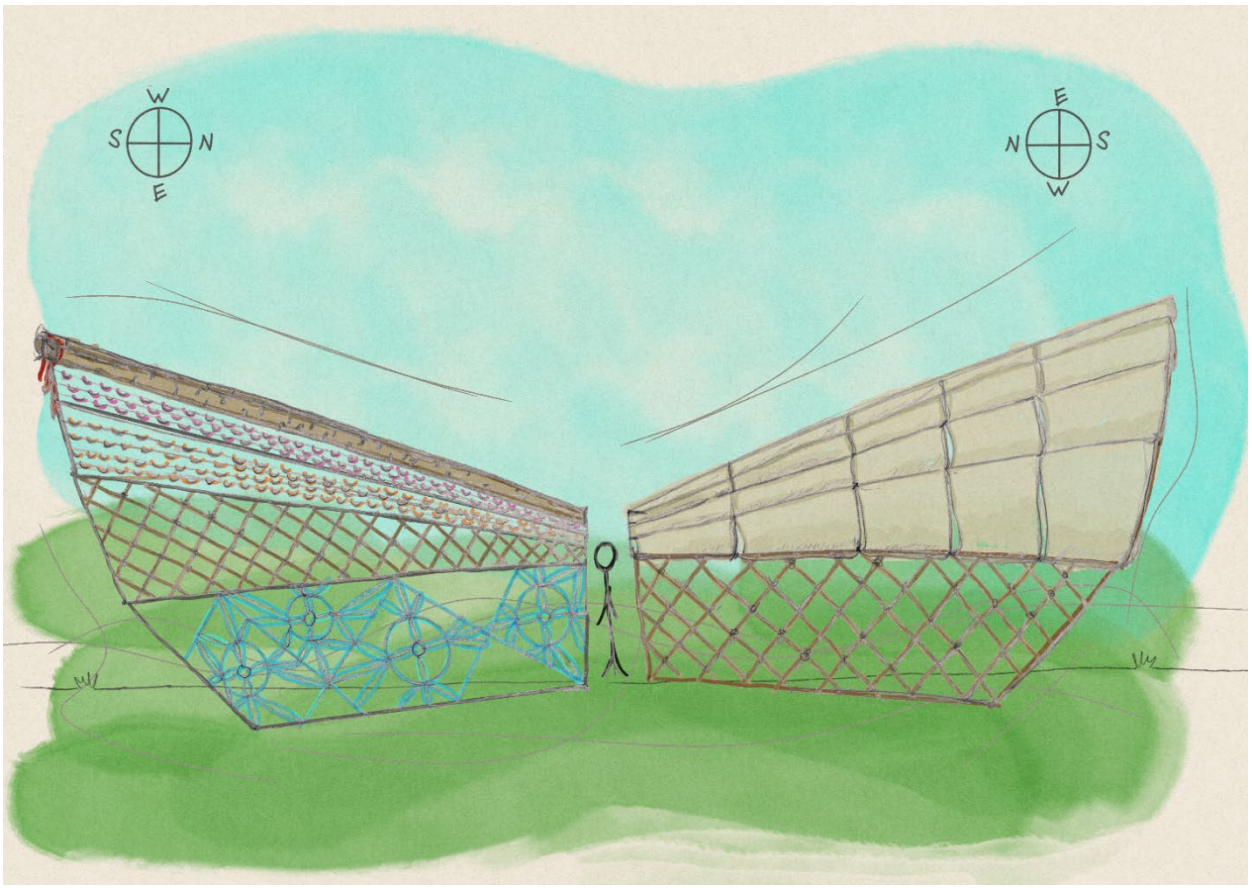


Figure 8: The centre structure of âniskômohcikewin*, spliced here into two parts, reveals 10 panels of varying material. Image on the left side: rope design inspired by hand drums and fish netting, rows of curved metal disks inspired by jingle cones are attached in rows, and two large birch trees tied with cotton fabric lay atop the structure. Image on the right: the rope fishnet pattern is repeated, and four panels of 20 large pieces of canvas fabric. These elements are interactive. They provide shade from the sun, movement, and gentle sounds. The canvas and jingle caps come most alive when engaging with the wind and rain.*

Spiritual and cultural practice

âniskômohcikewin encourages forms of cultural and spiritual practice by being near areas that already support similar activities. The seating around the fire pit and the cluster of river rocks can provide spaces for teachings, story sharing, community and land-based programming, or respite for those who were harvesting medicines, as well as a space for reflection in the winter and summer months. Elders, service providers, and knowledge keepers can engage, congregate, and facilitate a practice of spiritual reconnection. The symbolic meanings and shapes of drums, fishing nets, birch, and pow

wow regalia are integrated into the design, and are intended to inspire a non-linear practice of storytelling. The design of the small entryway into the central structure is intended to create a shift in perspective as people would traverse through space. The birch logs, the jingle cones, and fishing designs are meant to remind us of the joyous aspects of cultural practices, including the embrace of temporality described in previous sections of this thesis.

Interconnection

The design prioritizes interconnection by embracing natural, open concepts that are intended to bring people and the natural environment closer together. Rather than resisting Nature, the design allows Nature to play through and influence the space. Animals like rez dogs, magpies, and elements like rain and sunlight can freely interact and shape the structure. The texture of the natural wood slats, rope and birch logs further connects us to the textures of the land. The river rocks could link Elders to memories of lounging in the sun and swimming down the rapids, while simultaneously creating new memory-making opportunities for our youth. Warm fires during the summer nights or winter months would create more opportunities for social gatherings. The semi-shade created by the canvas material facing west encourages people to stay outside for longer during the summer and winter months. People are drawn to feel closer to the natural environment when observing Nature engaging with kinetic material in the centre structure: rain drops hitting dozens of jingle caps would make a symphony of "ting" sounds, the wind would ripple across the canvas pieces, and the sun and rain would erode and reshape the birch beams.





(Photos top to bottom: Examples of texture on snow-covered rock in near the pow wow arbour, March 2024; âniskômohcikewin *would repurpose discarded river rocks pictured here laying along on the riverbank less than 100 meters from the grounds, April 2024.)*

Familiarity and proximity

âniskômohcikewin's placement ties itself with the community's established spaces of cultural practice. The design highlights existing entities rather than replacing what exists. It is situated on the Treaty Grounds immediately near the land-based cabin (where there is coffee and crafting supplies), the community garden, and the bush (where occasional sweats lodges occur). It is situated in proximity to the Red Turtle Lodge, the township centre, and most notably, the river. To help people become more accustomed to the design, the materials reflect the environment and could be sourced locally. The only coloured elements would be the jingle bell caps and the repurposed

fishing rope (if made of bright nylon). Both are associated with positive aspects of the community's identity.

Accessible

The speculative design is intended to adapt to the year-round weather conditions and seasonal changes. There are few barriers to access: the ground near the land-based cabin is accessible by foot, car, and snowmobile. The land-based cabin parking lot is snowploughed during the winter, removing any additional barriers to year-round access. The wooden walkway travelling from the benches and underneath the center structure elevates people off the muddy earth of spring and fall and create traction during the winter months. Despite how the design's materials are intended to whither and be replaced, the subtle, underlying structure made of metal and treated wood would more easily adapt to elements like ice, snow, and floods. Most of the material for construction would be replaceable. Lumber, rope, birch, jingle cones, most material can be sourced from the local hardware store or from the land. Assuming the community adopts *âniskômohcikewin*, a few elected community members would volunteer to maintain and repair the structure over time. This design would always be open and accessible at all hours, further encouraging ritual and habit around community and exchange.

Enjoyable

Given that it is intended as a space for personal reflection and social gathering, playful expressions are used in connection and healing and are also an outcome of the process. For example, families can meet to share stories around a meal or coffee, helping others as community members heal each other with humour, care, and support, while others might feel comfortable simply sitting and looking into Nature. The interpretive design encourages subtle and unstructured forms of engagement. *âniskômohcikewin* fosters a sense of wonder, play, and joy to support healing and self-care, embodying the healing elements of playfulness while existing on a reserve not originally designed for play.

PART 7: Conclusion

This thesis explored the ways to design a place that evokes a sense of playful expression in Fisher River Cree Nation, Manitoba. I conducted my research with Ochekwi-Sipi, my First Nation community. My research highlighted the enduring presence of humour, play, and joy—all values essential for my community's holistic sense of well-being. These Indigenous values, once muted and dormant, have regained prominence through the community's efforts towards cultural revival. As Indigenous people, to play and be playful is a loving act of rebellion against colonial oppression. But beyond this, it is a form of joyful personal expression. Throughout my research, I sought to prove this through a literature review, observations of land and place, and by directly engaging with community through conversations and workshops.

The knowledge I gathered was transmitted through a reciprocal and relational methodology and a culturally appropriate participatory design framework. It took the entirety of my thesis to understand how accountability to my relations can be woven into playful design. I suspect it will continue long after this. I offered my capacity as a designer in ways I hoped would be beneficial to the community. For me, my effort goes beyond collecting information; it goes toward repairing the isolation and wariness that members feel in the community. My research efforts led to a nuanced list of six characteristics, and I hope they can help create a meaningful place for gathering on reserves, rather than a symbolic one. In other words, I believe I followed the best methods to create a speculative gathering place where people could feel the most capable in the things they do, rather than a place that's simply a mirror reflection of who they are.

My research is contextual and preliminary. Creating an Indigenous place for well-being requires a healthy and holistic activation of various grassroots entities within the larger socio-cultural environment. Additional work is required to study the implementation of a participatory place-based design of a playful gathering place on reserve. In later research, I hope to parse out the differences between a place that is inherently playful and one that can also activate playful engagement and expression

This was an opportunity to see the limits and strength of an Indigenous research paradigm as a status Cree woman of mixed descent who grew up nowhere near my reserve. I can support my Cree community and create moments for people to constructively discuss their future, all while weaving my own sense of belonging in this all-too-complicated definition of community. I see where I fit in, and I see where I don't. I, along with my sister, am discovering the alternative meaning to community as off-reserve

members. We will see what a future relationship with community will look like, despite there being no clear path forward for us. Perhaps she and I will forge a path towards a new form of research and relationality. On a more personal level, the words that I struggled with in this paper, community and place, have been reframed over the course of my two-year practice. The process of relationship-building has given nuance to these terms, and so a stronger bridge has been built between me and my ancestry.

As we move forward, we should remind ourselves to infuse a little laughter in our great journey toward reestablishing Indigenous presence. To continue to grow and understand what it means to be Indigenous and re-learn the joys of being ourselves. To realize when we no longer have to row the proverbial Treaty Bull, and start doing the Treaty Bull walk.

Laughter and joy are pleasurable, and (as I'm sure my Indigenous readers know) it's healing. When we take pleasure in things, we want more of it. When we apply this principle to an Indigenous research paradigm, what unfolds is a healthy approach towards improving Indigenous well-being. I'm glad I took part in shaping discourse around joy and play in my vibrant community.

As researchers, authors, and active community members, we are all cultural revitalizers. It's our responsibility to do away with the false premise of "objective research" and dismantle arcane norms in academic research, because how we decide to frame our understanding of community will determine how we can revitalize communities. When a narrative of scarcity and survival is internalized, it inhibits growth, self-acceptance, and joy in a pervasive, all-encompassing way. My research into *âniskômohcikewin* demonstrates the eternal presence of care, healing, and laughter in Ochekwi-Sipi. My community is not the exception. To support Indigenous resurgence, we must equally bring to light the joys of Indigeneity across Canada. It is an everlasting stream of light, and we must see it as an abundance, not a scarcity.

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